

DBT SKILLS FOR TEENS & ADULTS

Interpersonal Effectiveness: DEAR MAN, GIVE & FAST

What is interpersonal effectiveness?

Interpersonal effectiveness skills help you ask for what you need, say no, and handle conflict while keeping your relationships and your self-respect intact. They come from Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT), developed by Marsha Linehan.

Three goals in any interaction

Objective Effectiveness:

Getting what you want or need, or saying no to a request.

SKILL: DEAR MAN

Relationship Effectiveness:

Keeping or improving the relationship while you ask or say no.

SKILL: GIVE

Self-Respect Effectiveness:

Keeping or improving how you feel about yourself and staying true to your values.

SKILL: FAST

When to use each skill

I want something or need to say no	→ DEAR MAN
I want the other person to keep liking and respecting me	→ GIVE
I want to feel good about myself afterward	→ FAST

Most conversations use all three. Before you start, decide which goal matters most right now.



DEAR MAN

Getting what you want or saying no

D	**D - Describe:** Stick to the facts of the situation. No judgments.
E	**E - Express:** Share your feelings and opinions using "I" statements.
A	**A - Assert:** Ask clearly for what you want, or say no clearly.
R	**R - Reinforce:** Explain the positive effects of getting what you want, and reward the person ahead of time.
M	**M - stay Mindful:** Keep your focus on your goal. Use the "broken record" (calmly repeat your request) and ignore attacks or attempts to change the subject.
A	**A - Appear confident:** Use a confident tone and posture and make eye contact. Don't whisper, stare at the floor, or back down.
N	**N - Negotiate:** Be willing to give to get. Offer and ask for other solutions.

Example script: A teen asking to extend curfew

Describe:	"My friend's birthday party Saturday goes until 11, and my curfew is 10."
Express:	"I really want to be there for the whole thing because she's one of my closest friends."
Assert:	"Can I stay out until 11:30 this Saturday?"
Reinforce:	"If you say yes, I'll text you when I get there and when I leave, and I'll do my chores before I go."
Mindful:	"I hear that you're worried. I'm still asking about 11:30 for this one night."
Appear confident:	Calm voice, eye contact, sitting up straight.
Negotiate:	"If 11:30 is too late, could I stay until 11 and have you pick me up?"

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GIVE

Keeping the relationship



G — **G - be Gentle:** No attacks, no threats, no judging, no sneering or eye-rolling.

Example phrases: "I'd like to talk about something that's been on my mind." "I know this is hard to hear."

I — **I - act Interested:** Listen and show interest in the other person's point of view. Don't interrupt.

Example phrases: "Tell me more about that." "What do you think would work?"

V — **V - Validate:** Show that you understand the other person's feelings and situation, out loud.

Example phrases: "I can see why you'd feel that way." "That makes sense, you've had a really busy week."

E — **E - use an Easy manner:** Use a little humor, smile, and be lighthearted. Ease the person along.

Example phrases: "I know, I know, I'm asking again!" "Let's figure this out together."

Tip: GIVE helps the other person feel respected, which makes them more willing to hear you.

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FAST

Keeping your self-respect



F

F - be Fair:

Be fair to yourself and to the other person.

Example phrases:

"My needs matter, and so do yours." "Let's find something that works for both of us."

A

A - no (excessive) Apologies:

Don't apologize for making a request, having an opinion, or disagreeing.

Example phrases:

"I'd like to ask for..." (instead of "Sorry, I know this is dumb, but...") "I see it differently."

S

S - Stick to your values:

Don't give up your values or integrity just to get what you want or to be liked.

Example phrases:

"That's not something I'm comfortable doing." "Honesty is important to me."

T

T - be Truthful:

Don't lie, act helpless when you're not, or exaggerate.

Example phrases:

"The truth is, I forgot." "I can do part of it, but not all of it."

Tip:

Ask yourself, "How do I want to feel about myself when this conversation is over?"

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Putting It Together

A quick prep worksheet



1. What's my goal?

What do I want from this person? _____

How do I want them to feel about me afterward? _____

How do I want to feel about myself afterward? _____

2. Which skill has priority?

- ☐ DEAR MAN (my objective)
- ☐ GIVE (the relationship)
- ☐ FAST (my self-respect)

Tip: Choosing your priority.

If getting what you want matters most, lead with DEAR MAN. If the relationship matters most, lean on GIVE. If you might give up your values, protect your self-respect with FAST. You can still use all three.

3. My DEAR MAN script

Describe: _____

Express: _____

Assert: _____

Reinforce: _____

Mindful (my broken-record line): _____

Appear confident (how I will look and sound): _____

Negotiate (what I can offer): _____

4. Reflection (after the conversation):

What went well? _____

What would I try differently next time? _____

Adapted from Linehan, M. M. (2015). DBT Skills Training Handouts and Worksheets (2nd ed.).